ruling dispensation?[2] It was even embarrassing to see the once-mighty Congress party reduced to a chaotic circus (for that's what the Yatra's launch looked like to most onlookers, no matter how positively inclined they were to the party).

But as Rahul trudged through the southern states, support for the Yatra grew. From the few thousand people who had started the yatra, before one knew it, there were lakhs of people following him. The best part about this was that they were not all from the Congress party. In fact, since I religiously followed the Yatra's social media handles, I could spot several civic society activists I knew and who were at loggerheads with the Congress party when it was in power. That was the first time I felt that the Yatra was definitely trying to '*jodo Bharat* (unite India)', since it was succeeding in its stated aim of bringing people together.

By the time the Yatra reached Karnataka, several of my friends were already walking with it in solidarity. As it slowly made its way north, it seemed like a gentle beast stretching itself after a long hibernation. The crowds had swelled to lakhs, with people joining the walk impromptu. The Yatra had almost attained the status of a festival—a Bharat Jodo festival. By now, many of us were cheering it along on various platforms, some openly and some with restraint. In my circles at least, the Yatra was forging a bond and we were impatiently watching as it inched closer to Maharashtra (my state). By the time it was within grasp, I could barely sit still. I was so excited that I couldn't stop myself from joining it!

Which brought me to my first hurdle. The Yatra was going to pass through Nanded, which is a good sixteen hours' drive from where I live. The notion of driving so far was daunting. But if a man was going to walk almost 4,000 kilometres across our nation to just stand against hate and bring us together, surely I could make a little effort myself? My friend mocked me for daftly falling for the wily charms of a politician. Others cautioned me, saying, 'You are joining the losing side.'

While I have consciously stayed away from any political affiliations, Rahul was no longer a politician for me. I saw him as a person, with his heart in the right place and a spirit to back up that. And so, ignoring all the